MODULE 27 · DOMAIN 6 - STAKEHOLDER COMMUNICATION AND LIFECYCLE

Communicating Decisions: Audiences and ADRs

One decision, packaged for executives, product, security and engineering; layering for mixed audiences and steering committees; and architecture decision records that keep the roads not taken.

DOMAIN 6 of 7 EXAM WEIGHT 14% MODULE 27 of 38

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A ship's log records every change of course, and why. **A good decision record keeps the roads not taken.**

One decision, four audiences

AUDIENCE	CARES ABOUT	LEAD WITH
Executive	Outcomes, cost, risk	The decision and its business impact
Product	Capabilities, users, roadmap	What users get, when, and dependencies
Security and compliance	Threats, controls, evidence	Data flows, controls, residual risk
Engineering	Contracts, flows, failures	Interfaces, sequence, alternatives

THE TIEBREAKER

Same decision, different package. Match the content to what the audience must act on.

Briefing an executive

- **Decision first,** in one sentence, then why it matters.
- **Outcomes in business measures:** cost, time, risk, customer impact.
- **Trade-offs in plain terms:** what we gain, what we give up.
- **Risk at a high level,** each with an owner.
- **The ask:** the approval or decision you need, and by when.
- **Leave out:** token counts, model internals, architecture diagrams.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> If the executive has to read to the end to find the decision, the briefing failed.

Translate the trade-off into the audience's terms

CHOICE	ENGINEERING FRAMING	EXECUTIVE FRAMING
Smaller model tier	Lower latency and cost per call	Faster answers, lower cost; hard cases go to a person
Prompt caching	Cache reads on the stable prefix	Same answers, lower running cost
Human approval	Review queue adds latency	Slower, but no unreviewed reply reaches a customer
Batch API	Asynchronous, within 24 hours, 50% off	Next-day results at half the cost

THE TIEBREAKER

Engineers hear mechanisms. Executives hear consequences. Both must be true.

The security and compliance package

- **Data flows** with trust boundaries: what reaches Claude, where it is processed.
- **Threat model:** prompt injection, data leakage, over-permissioned tools.
- **Control mapping** to their framework, such as HIPAA safeguards or UK GDPR.
- **Residual risk,** stated plainly, and accepted by a named owner.
- **Evidence:** audit trail, retention, platform terms, test results.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Security reviewers approve evidence, not reassurance. Never hide residual risk.

Explaining a probabilistic system honestly

- **Use natural frequencies:** "about 91 in 100 on our test set of real complaints".
- **Say what the test set represents,** and what it does not.
- **Name the failure modes,** and what catches each one.
- **Separate measured from expected,** and pilot from production.
- **Avoid:** "never wrong", "the AI understands", or a single number with no context.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Promise what you measured, on the data you measured it on. Nothing more.

Present options against criteria, not adjectives

OPTION	HANDLER APPROVAL RULE	HANDLER TIME SAVED	MAIN RISK
Classify only	Met	Low	Little value
Draft, handler approves	Met	High	Rubber-stamping
Send replies automatically	Fails	Highest	Unreviewed errors reach members

THE TIEBREAKER

A hard requirement removes an option before any trade-off is weighed. Show that, then compare the rest.

Layering for a mixed audience

01
Decision
What we recommend, in one line.

02
Why
The outcome it serves.

03
Options
What we compared, and the criteria.

04
Trade-offs
Gains, costs, risks with owners.

05
The ask
What we need from this room.

06
Appendices
Detail per audience.

ON THE EXAM

Everyone reads the top. Each specialist drills into their own appendix.

Steering committees: bring a decision, not a status

- **State the decision needed** at the top of the paper.
- **Options with a recommendation,** and the criteria behind it.
- **What happens if they say no,** or decide later.
- **Risks and owners;** what changed since last time.
- **Not:** a sprint report, or a walk through every component.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A committee exists to decide. Give it something to decide.

What an ADR contains

SECTION	WHAT IT HOLDS
Title and status	Proposed, accepted, or superseded by a later ADR
Context	Forces, constraints, the requirements it traces to
Decision	What we will do, stated plainly
Alternatives and criteria	Options considered, and why each was rejected
Consequences	Gains, costs, risks, follow-up work
Date, authors, owner	Who decided, when, and who keeps it current
Review trigger	The event that reopens it

THE TIEBREAKER

No alternatives, no ADR. The roads not taken are the point.

Quirk 11: the ADR with no road not taken

AS FIRST WRITTEN

ADR 014, Mereside retrieval

```
Status: accepted
Decision: chunk the policy
library on headings and clauses,
and add contextual retrieval.

Consequences: better answers.
```

A reader cannot tell what was rejected, or when to revisit.

AS REVISED

ADR 014, Mereside retrieval

```
Context: exceptions sit in the clause
after the rule; 1,800 documents.
Alternatives: whole library in prompt,
rejected on size and cost. Larger
fixed chunks, rejected on recall.
Consequences: re-index on publish.
Owner: retrieval lead. Review: new
embedding model or library doubles.
```

The roads not taken, the cost, the owner and the trigger.

THE TIEBREAKER

If a new architect could not tell why the obvious alternative was rejected, the ADR is incomplete.

ADR habits that keep the log useful

- **One decision per ADR,** written when it is made, not at handoff.
- **Accepted ADRs are not edited.** A new ADR supersedes the old one.
- **Link the evidence:** requirements, evaluation results, cost figures.
- **Review triggers** such as a new model generation, a price change, or a volume step.
- **Store ADRs with the code,** where engineers will find them.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The log is history. You add to it. You never rewrite it.

Using Claude to adapt one decision for many audiences

- **Start from one source:** the ADR and its evidence.
- **Ask for each audience's package** with its role, what it acts on, and length.
- **Forbid new facts:** only figures and claims from the source.
- **Check every number and risk** against the source before it goes out.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Claude adapts the telling. The architect owns the truth of every version.

> Mereside's chief operating officer must approve running agent assist on Amazon Bedrock in a European region rather than the first-party API.
>
> She has ten minutes and asks for a briefing.

What should Corvane lead with?

A. A full architecture diagram, so she sees every component involved

B. The recommendation, its business impact on regional processing and cost, and the approval needed

C. A table of per-token prices across both platforms and every model tier, with monthly projections

D. The complete decision log, so nothing is hidden from her

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane lead with?

A. A full architecture diagram, so she sees every component involved

Detail for engineers, not a decision aid.

B. The recommendation, its business impact on regional processing and cost, and the approval needed

Decision first, impact, then the ask.

C. A table of per-token prices across both platforms and every model tier, with monthly projections

Raw prices are not business impact.

D. The complete decision log, so nothing is hidden from her

Transparency, but she cannot decide from it.

THE SIGNAL

Executives get the decision, its business impact, and the ask, first.

> Quillon's chief information security officer must approve the discharge-summary agent before it reads live patient records.
>
> She asks for a review pack.

What should the pack contain?

A Benchmark results showing the agent is faster than clinicians

B The product roadmap for the next three releases

C Data flows, a threat model, controls mapped to HIPAA safeguards, residual risk with an owner, and evidence

D A statement that Anthropic's platform is secure and HIPAA-ready, with links to its compliance pages

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the pack contain?

A Benchmark results showing the agent is faster than clinicians

Speed is not a security question.

B The product roadmap for the next three releases

A product audience's package.

C Data flows, a threat model, controls mapped to HIPAA safeguards, residual risk with an owner, and evidence

Evidence a reviewer can approve.

D A statement that Anthropic's platform is secure and HIPAA-ready, with links to its compliance pages

Reassurance, not evidence about this system.

THE SIGNAL

Security reviewers approve evidence about this system, including the risk you could not remove.

> Tallyhawk's product managers ask what the redesigned support agent means for their plans.
>
> The redesign splits it into billing, scheduling and account agents.

What should Corvane give them?

A. The new agents' system prompts and tool schemas, so they can see exactly how it works

B. A threat model for each of the three agents

C. A cost breakdown of tokens per conversation

D. What customers can do in each release, what is not supported, and roadmap dependencies

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane give them?

A The new agents' system prompts and tool schemas, so they can see exactly how it works
An engineering artefact.

B A threat model for each of the three agents
A security artefact.

C A cost breakdown of tokens per conversation
Useful to finance, not to product planning.

D What customers can do in each release, what is not supported, and roadmap dependencies
Capabilities, limits and dependencies.

THE SIGNAL

Product owners plan around capabilities, limits and dependencies.

> Mereside's steering committee meets on extending complaints triage to posted letters.
>
> Members include the chief operating officer, the data protection officer, IT and the head of complaints.

How should Corvane structure the paper?

A. Decision and recommendation first, options and trade-offs, risks with owners, the ask, then an appendix for each function

B. Separate papers for each member, each written in their own terms

C. A full technical walk-through of the design, since IT will ask the hardest questions on the day

D. A progress report on the last sprint, with the decision raised at the end

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should Corvane structure the paper?

A. Decision and recommendation first, options and trade-offs, risks with owners, the ask, then an appendix for each function

Layered: one decision, detail on demand.

B. Separate papers for each member, each written in their own terms

Fragments the decision across four stories.

C. A full technical walk-through of the design, since IT will ask the hardest questions on the day

Serves one member, loses the rest.

D. A progress report on the last sprint, with the decision raised at the end

Status first buries the decision.

THE SIGNAL

Mixed rooms get one layered paper, decision first, with an appendix for each specialist.

> Corvane's reviewer reads a junior architect's ADR for Mereside's retrieval design.
>
> It states the decision and "better answers" as the only consequence.

What is the most important addition?

A More implementation detail about the chunking code

B Alternatives considered, the criteria, why each was rejected, and real consequences

C An executive summary at the top, so the committee can read the decision quickly

D A diagram of the final retrieval pipeline

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the most important addition?

A More implementation detail about the chunking code

Belongs in the code, not the ADR.

B Alternatives considered, the criteria, why each was rejected, and real consequences

The roads not taken, and the costs.

C An executive summary at the top, so the committee can read the decision quickly

Helpful, but it summarises what is missing.

D A diagram of the final retrieval pipeline

Shows the result, not the reasoning.

THE SIGNAL

An ADR without alternatives records an outcome, not a decision.

> Tallyhawk's integration-fault agent moved from loading all tools to tool search.
>
> An engineer proposes editing the original accepted ADR so it describes tool search instead.

What should Corvane advise?

A Edit the original, so the log matches the system today

B Delete the original, since it no longer applies

C Write a new ADR that supersedes it, and mark the original as superseded

D Note the change in a code comment, and leave the log alone

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane advise?

A Edit the original, so the log matches the system today

Rewrites history; loses why it changed.

B Delete the original, since it no longer applies

Loses the record entirely.

C Write a new ADR that supersedes it, and mark the original as superseded

History kept; the new reasons recorded.

D Note the change in a code comment, and leave the log alone

The log then contradicts the system.

THE SIGNAL

Accepted ADRs are never edited. A new record supersedes them, and both stay in the log.

> Corvane is setting a minimum standard for every ADR it writes for clients.

Which two must every ADR include? Choose two.

A The full transcript of the design meeting

B The implementation code for the decision

C The alternatives considered, with the criteria used

D A vendor comparison deck from the sales process

E The consequences, including the negative ones

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two must every ADR include? Choose two.

A The full transcript of the design meeting

Too long. Summarise the context instead.

B The implementation code for the decision

Belongs in the repository.

C The alternatives considered, with the criteria used

The roads not taken.

D A vendor comparison deck from the sales process

Not a decision record.

E The consequences, including the negative ones

Costs and risks, as well as gains.

THE SIGNAL

Alternatives and honest consequences are what make a record a decision record.

In five lines

- **One decision, many packages:** match content to what each audience acts on.
- **Executives:** decision first, business impact, the ask.
- **Security:** flows, threats, controls, residual risk, evidence.
- **Mixed rooms and committees:** one layered paper, a decision to make.
- **ADRs:** alternatives and consequences; supersede, never edit.

COMING UP

Next: feedback loops, expectations and SLAs.